

Question 45 · Unit 3 · 8 Marks

Explain the Kirkpatrick model for evaluating training effectiveness.

Introduction

Donald Kirkpatrick's model is the most famous framework for judging whether training worked. It has four levels, usually seen as a ladder: each level is more difficult to measure and more important for the organisation. The training cycle's Stage 4 (evaluation) often uses this model. Outcomes must be related to the objectives of the programme.

Detailed points

- 1. Level 1 — Reaction (affective outcomes).** Did participants like the programme? Was it relevant, comfortable, well trained? Measured by feedback forms ('smile sheets'). Useful for improving hospitality and trainer style, but liking is not learning.
- 2. Level 2 — Learning.** Did they gain the intended knowledge, skill or attitude? Measured by tests, demonstrations, pre-post comparison, role-play scores. If level 2 is weak, later levels cannot honestly succeed.
- 3. Level 3 — Behaviour (transfer).** Do they use it on the job after some time? Measured by observation, supervisor ratings, 360 feedback, work samples. This is where most programmes die because climate and bosses do not support new behaviour.
- 4. Level 4 — Results.** Did the organisation benefit — quality, productivity, errors, sales, safety, customer satisfaction, costs? Notes also say impact on corporate objectives. Hard to prove cause, but this is why the company paid.
- 5. Logic of the hierarchy.** Good reaction helps learning; learning is needed for behaviour; behaviour should produce results. But each step can fail even if the previous succeeded. Therefore all levels matter.
- 6. Design implication.** Decide measures during TNA and design, not after the valedictory function. Collect baseline (before training) for levels 2–4.
- 7. Importance for HRD.** Stops HRD from claiming success on attendance and tea quality. Raises professionalism.
- 8. Limitations.** Causality at level 4 is messy; not all outcomes are numeric; full four-level evaluation is costly — use proportionately (critical safety training vs a one-hour talk). Still the best simple map of effectiveness.

Conclusion. Name and explain four levels with measures, state the ladder logic, mention design and limits. Kirkpatrick asks: not only 'did they enjoy?' but 'did they learn, do, and improve results?'